



For Parents, Carers and Guardians

Cyberbullying and Online Abuse: A Guide for Parents

Recognising online bullying and abuse, talking with your child, handling messages safely, and working with the school.

Before You Read

This guide covers online bullying, threats and messages encouraging self-harm.

This guide is about cyberbullying and online abuse, including threats of violence and messages that encourage a child to harm themselves. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with your own experience or your child's.

- If you are worried about your child now, contact the school's safeguarding team. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000, for anyone worried about a child.
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free, any time, day or night.

About This Guide

Children's online and offline lives are one life. This guide helps you recognise when your child is being bullied or abused online, talk with them about it, handle messages safely, and work with the school.

- It can come from classmates, a group chat, strangers, or an anonymous account.
- Any child can be targeted, and any child can be drawn into hurting others online. Both need help.
- Threats of violence and messages encouraging self-harm are serious from the first message.
Don't wait for a pattern.

If Messages Tell Your Child to Hurt Themselves

- **Talk to your child today.** Ask calmly and directly whether they have had thoughts of hurting themselves. Asking does not put the idea in their head.

- Stay with them if you are worried about their safety now. If they have hurt themselves and need help, or you think their life is at risk, **call 999**.
- **NHS 111**: call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online.
- Tell the school's safeguarding team as soon as you can, so they can support your child in school.
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline**: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm).

Key Words

Cyberbullying

Bullying through phones, apps, games or the internet: repeated, deliberate hurting of a child by others, where the child finds it hard to make it stop.

Online abuse

Any harm done online, including threats, harassment, humiliation and abuse aimed at who someone is. One message can be enough.

Anonymous account

An account that hides who is behind it. It may be someone your child knows.

Pile-on

When a group joins in against one child, by commenting, liking or sharing.

What the Evidence Shows

23%

of 8 to 17 year olds had experienced nasty or hurtful behaviour in the past 12 months

Ofcom, 2026

72%

of 10 to 15 year olds who experienced online bullying said at least some happened at school or in school time

ONS, 2020

26%

of those 10 to 15 year olds had told no one

ONS, 2020

The ONS figures are from the year ending March 2020, the most recent official statistics on online bullying. Checked September 2026.

What It Can Look Like at Different Ages

Age	What you might see
8 to 11	Unkind messages in games or family devices, being left out of group chats, early social media use. Children this age may not have the words for it, or may worry they'll lose the device if they tell.
11 to 14	Group chat pile-ons, mocking posts, fake accounts, anonymous messages.
14 to 18	Harassment, threats, abuse about identity, rumours about relationships, edited or AI-made images, and pressure involving sexual images.

Signs to Look For

Your Child May Be Targeted If They

- Seem anxious, upset or jumpy when their phone or device notifies them
- Stop using a device or app suddenly, or can't stop checking it
- Are tired, or on their phone late at night
- Don't want to go to school, or avoid friends and activities
- Seem low, or say things like everyone would be better off without them

Your Child May Be Involved in Hurting Someone If They

- Laugh about, or show you, content about another child
- Have accounts you don't know about, or hide their screen
- Talk about a child in their group being "annoying" or "deserving it"
- Call it "just banter"

A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before contacting the school.

Talking with Your Child

- **Stay calm.** If you react with anger or panic, children often stop telling. Your calm helps them feel safe.
- **Listen first.** "Tell me what's been happening." Avoid "why" questions, which can sound like blame.
- **Believe them,** and say it isn't their fault: "This is not your fault. No one deserves messages like that."
- **Don't take their phone away** as a response to them telling you. It can feel like a punishment and stop them telling you next time.
- **Don't tell them to just ignore it.** Help them decide what to do, with the school.
- **Keep talking** about their online life in everyday moments, not only when something goes wrong.

What to Do with Messages and Posts

Keeping Evidence Safely

- **Don't reply** to the account, and ask your child not to reply either.
- **Don't delete anything yet.** Keep the messages as they are, and write down when they arrived. Contact the school, which will advise on how the evidence is preserved.
- **Never screenshot, save, forward or share a nude or sexual image of a child,** even as evidence and even of your own child. It can be a criminal offence. Tell the school or the police instead.
- **Block and report** the account on the app. Ask the school or police about timing if you can, but if your child needs to block someone now to feel safe, that comes first.
- **Report Harmful Content (UK Safer Internet Centre):** reportharmfulcontent.com, for anyone 13 or over in the UK, about threats, bullying and harassment, impersonation, self-harm or suicide content and other harmful content, once you have reported it to the platform and at least 48 hours have passed.
- **Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation):** helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk.
- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency):** ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse or grooming. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking. Use it if someone is asking your child for sexual images, trying to meet them, or you think an adult is involved.

If Your Child Tells You Something

What to Do

- **Stay calm and listen.** Say: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- If there are threats of violence, find out if your child is worried about a particular time or place. If they are in danger, call 999.
- **Don't contact the other child or their family, and don't post about it online.** It can escalate things, put your child at more risk, and affect what the school and police can do.
- Don't try to find out who is behind an anonymous account.
- Write down what your child said, in their words, and when, as soon as is practicably possible.
- Contact the school's safeguarding team, even if it happened outside school. Online bullying often involves students from the same school, and it affects school life.

If You're Worried About Your Child's Behaviour

Finding out your child has been part of hurting someone online is hard. It doesn't make them a bad person. Children often join in to fit in or to avoid being targeted. They still need to take responsibility.

First, Check With the School

If another child may be involved or at risk, **contact the school's safeguarding team before raising it with your child.** Agree how and when to talk to them, so that the conversation does not increase the risk to anyone, for example by revealing that the other child has asked for help, or leading to messages being deleted.

- Then talk calmly about what happened and how the other child may feel.
- Ask them not to delete anything until the school says what is needed.
- Work with the school on consequences and support. Some online behaviour can be a crime; the school will explain what happens next.

How the School Responds

Schools using **RESPOND** follow a seven-step approach that helps staff respond consistently when they notice or are told about harm.

For children, safeguarding is **relational**: they tell people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: behind every trusted adult is a safeguarding team, with records and procedures that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help. That is why staff can't promise to keep something just between them and your child.

Step	What staff do
● Recognise	Notice the signs, including online, and treat threats and self-harm messages as urgent
● Engage	Listen calmly, believe the child, and ask directly about their safety
● Support	Make sure the child is safe today, including any risk of self-harm
● Pause	Think before acting; never investigate the account or confront other students without a plan
● Offer	Model alternatives and explain what happens next
● Notify	Tell the safeguarding team as soon as is practicably possible, and immediately where there is risk
● Document	Record what happened, factually

Working with You

- **Parents and carers are partners in keeping children safe.** You know your child best.
- The school will usually involve you when there is a concern about your child.
- Schools can share safeguarding information without asking for consent where it is needed to keep a child safe; data protection law allows this. From 30 September 2026, a new Information Sharing Duty also requires many safeguarding organisations to share relevant information. What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Schools should tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put a child at greater risk, and listen to your views and your child's.
- Sometimes the school must speak to other agencies before telling parents, where telling parents first could increase the risk to a child. That decision depends on the circumstances, and it is always about the child's safety.
- The school's safeguarding lead decides how messages are kept as evidence, whether to involve the police, and how any students responsible are approached. Staff won't copy or forward images of children.
- Every child involved gets a response: the child targeted, the children responsible, and the bystanders.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's only online, it's not real"	Online abuse can cause real distress and follows children home, into their bedrooms at night.
"Taking away the phone will fix it"	It can feel like a punishment for telling, and cut your child off from friends. Plan changes together.
"Just ignore it"	Threats and self-harm messages always need action. Ignoring can leave a child on their own with it.
"I should confront the other parents"	It can escalate things and make your child less safe. Go through the school.
"Asking about self-harm will put ideas in their head"	Asking calmly and directly is safe, and it shows your child they can talk to you.

Who Can Help

At School

- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep children safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline:** 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)

- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- **NHS 111:** call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online
- **Childline** (for your child): 0800 1111, free, confidential, any time, or [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk)
- **Emergency:** call 999; police non-emergency: 101

Contacts checked September 2026.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Parent Guides

Cyberbullying and Online Abuse: A Guide for Parents: Parent Guide 3 - Ages 8 to 18

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